



Giant killer: Amanda Anisimova beat Iga Swiatek and Naomi Osaka in back-to-back matches to reach the final. REUTERS

walkover from Marketa Vondrousova, the talented Czech lefty and 2023 Wimbledon champion. Vondrousova left the site in tears, citing a knee injury, but not before knocking out No. 7 Jasmine Paolini, a breakout star last year, 7-6(4), 6-1, and heavy-hitting Elena Rybakina 6-4, 5-7, 6-2.

The most heartwarming story of the fortnight came in a quarterfinal rematch of the Wimbledon final. Iga Swiatek made history with a 6-0, 6-0 demolition of Anisimova, the first double-bagel singles final there in the Open Era. **Anisimova turned the tables at Flushing Meadows, though, making auspicious history herself: she became the first such victim to reach the final of the next Grand Slam event.**

But Anisimova, like Sabalenka,

learned from her bitter defeat. On her Wimbledon debacle, she said, “It gave me a better perspective on how I should be handling my nerves.” Embarrassingly slow in the Wimbledon final, Anisimova imposed her powerful groundstrokes on Swiatek, attacked her second serve, and kept the speedy Polish superstar on the run throughout the impressive 6-4, 6-3 quarterfinal upset. “Today proved everything for me,” said the resilient Anisimova. “It proved I can do it.”

Anisimova would have to prove her prowess and poise again in the semifinals against the resurgent Naomi Osaka. The Japanese veteran had finally regained the form that brought her two Australian Open and two U.S. Open titles from 2018 to 2021. After giving birth to a girl in 2023, she struggled and occasionally seemed to sour on the sport, only to regain her passion this summer.

The most intriguing fourth-round match pitted Gauff — seeded No. 3 but mired in a deep slump since

winning her second Major at the French Open — against Osaka. Double faults were Gauff’s exasperating *bete noire*, as she was then averaging 11 per match. Gauff made the rare and controversial decision to revamp her flawed serve technique in the short span of a week, and even more questionably, just before the U.S. Open. Biomechanics guru Gavin MacMillan, whom Sabalenka credited with correcting her service woes, instructed Gauff to keep her head and tossing arm up longer, use a more closed shoulder rotation, and toss the ball farther over her left shoulder. Gauff notched good wins over Ajla Tomljanovic (who defeated Serena Williams in her 2022 farewell here), Olympic silver medallist Donna Vekic, and 28th-seed Magdalena Frech. But could her new serve, and the hastily instilled muscle memory required, hold up against the revitalised Osaka?

Ironically, it was Gauff’s technically flawed Western forehand and not her serve that broke down against Osaka. Of Gauff’s 33 unforced errors, 20 came from the suspect forehand and only five from double faults. Sensing her opponent’s anxiety, Osaka targeted the vulnerable forehand and surged to a 6-3, 6-2 victory.

The 27-year-old Japanese, who resides in Los Angeles, had never lost a Major quarterfinal, and that success continued when she matched spectacular shots with Karolina Muchova. Sporting a purple, sparkling, double-hemmed dress against Muchova, Osaka said, “I’m not thinking about winning at all. I’m just trying to have fun.” The formula worked as she tempered her ferocious power with just enough consistency to prevail 6-4, 7-6 (3). “My dream is coming true,” Osaka exulted afterward.

But that dream ended in her semifinal slugfest with Anisimova.

Like two heavyweight boxers punching and counter-punching violently, Osaka and Anisimova pounded away in the opening set, each breaking serve twice. Points were shorter than in most men’s